practices. Like many other developments, borderless politics, too, spans a broad spectrum. At one end, there is a desire to assist fellow travellers and those with shared benefits and interests. On the other extreme are endeavours that lead to radicalization, violent extremism or even terrorism.

Then there is the securitizing of the routine. We tend to think of dangers and vulnerabilities as arising from unusual situations: a conflict, a clash, a disturbance or preparations for them. But modern life has taken us into a web of technologies, activities and instruments that can be utilized without the user or the target even being aware. Every day, in myriad ways, we are exposed to risks of different kinds. The most obvious example is that of data and the processes that help generate it. How data is harvested and AI is developed is one of the most intense areas of global contestation. It could be digital transactions and the cyber world that have become so much more salient in our daily routine or the critical infrastructure on which a society is so dependent.

In fact, the Covid experience taught us how even domains unconnected with technology can enhance our vulnerability. In a world of supply chains, shortages can emerge at sensitive moments in key areas. This may be the outcome of logistical disruption, but equally of a planned strategy. As a result, global concerns have focussed more on resilient, reliable and redundant supply chains and, in the digital world, on greater trust and transparency.

The real problem, however, is the weaponization of everything. In recent years, the world has recognized how domains like trade, finance, investment and logistics can be leveraged for strategic purposes. Indeed, market shares and sectoral dominance have been created with that very end in mind. Some nations have put forward entire initiatives that advance objectives that remain hidden until it is too late. Others have been starker, like in the application of sanctions as means of pressure.

Once the mindset of weaponization sets in, almost nothing is safe. It can be directing or withholding the flow of tourists, the supply of raw materials and components or exercising the power of a large vendor or customer. When the market economy is subjugated to non-market goals, we then realize how the normal has added to fragility. In truth, the world has long lived in a twilight zone where rules were manipulated for globalization gains. Now that the chickens are coming home to roost, we are belatedly waking up to the resulting concerns. Ironically, when strategy demands,